

Leaves of the dumb cane

THE DUMB CANE
The name of this plant comes from its poisonous sap. If this is swallowed, it makes the mouth swell so much that talking becomes difficult.

DRINK OR DRUG?
The mescal cactus contains a hallucinogenic substance called mescaline, which is used in the religious rituals of certain Mexican Indian tribes. Confusingly, the drink mescal (or mezcal) is not derived from the mescal cactus, but from the agave plant, which is also native to Mexico.



Mescal cactus

Mescal, a drink made from the agave plant

DEADLY BERRIES
The drug atropine, which is used in eye surgery and to treat stomach complaints, is derived from a very poisonous plant called belladonna, or deadly nightshade.

FROM COCA TO COCAINE
Many centuries ago, South American Indians discovered that chewing the leaves of the coca plant dulled pain and prevented tiredness. Coca leaves contain the drug cocaine. Although a valuable anesthetic, cocaine can be dangerously addictive.



Coca leaves for sale

Coca leaves

Drinking gin and tonic water in India, at the end of the 19th century



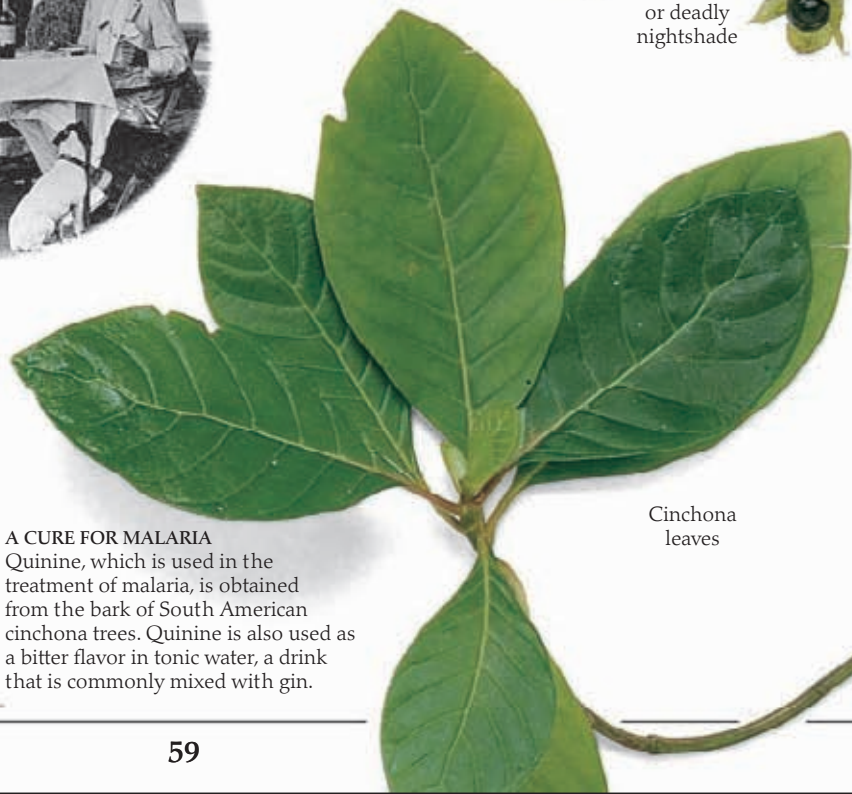
Foxglove

HELP FOR THE HEART

The leaves of the foxglove contain a substance that is used to treat heart conditions. In large doses, it produces palpitations and dizziness, but in small doses, it helps the heart to beat more slowly and strongly.



A CURE FOR MALARIA
Quinine, which is used in the treatment of malaria, is obtained from the bark of South American cinchona trees. Quinine is also used as a bitter flavor in tonic water, a drink that is commonly mixed with gin.



Cinchona leaves

Belladonna, or deadly nightshade

